

Antecedent and consequent

When an antecedent and consequent phrase are connected, the entire thing is called a period. Ante is Latin for “before,” and consequent is Latin for “following.” Antecedent phrases almost always end on a whole note that is part of the V chord, which is built on scale degree 5.

▽ Parallel period

This example of Brahms’s theme, as well as “Mary Had a Little Lamb,” are both parallel periods. This means that the antecedent and the consequent phrases are very similar.

Antecedent

Consequent

Phrase moves from tonic (F Major) to the dominant (C Major)

Here the consequent phrase ends by emphasizing a perfect V-I for finality.

This is a question phrase, ending with an upward motion to the dominant or V chord.

Antecedent

Consequent

Row, row, row your boat gently down the stream.

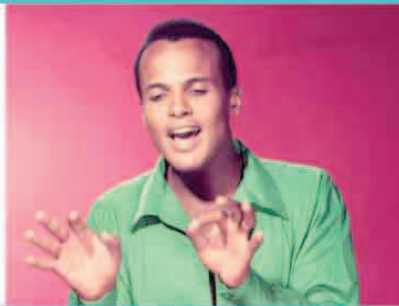
Mer - ri - ly, Mer - ri - ly, Mer - ri - ly, Mer - ri - ly, life is but a dream.

Ends on the tonic, scale degree 1.

REAL WORLD

Call-and-response

The call-and-response technique has been adopted by many composers. Often the call phrase changes, but the response phrase stays the same. One of the most popular call-and-response tunes is Harry Belafonte’s 1956 recording of the “Banana Boat Song.” In this traditional Jamaican tune, the call changes frequently, but the response phrase is always “Daylight come and I wan’ go home.”



△ Contrasting period

Contrasting periods are rhythmically and melodically different from one another. Here phrase one uses longer note values in an ascending contour, while phrase two has shorter notes and travels downward.